

Restaurant POS — 2 Fast-Casual Taco Shops \$1.2M — Square + Tablets to Unified System

Executive summary — Owner of two fast-casual taco shops in Austin — South Lamar open 3 years, Burnet open 11 months, 35 employees total, \$1.2M combined annual sales, owner handles ops, wife handles marketing, margins slipping. Current stack: Square POS on iPads since day one, DoorDash tablet, Uber Eats tablet, handwritten kitchen tickets, no inventory tracking eyeball method. Volume: 1,800 tickets/week across both, 40% takeout, 25% delivery (DoorDash/Uber), 35% dine-in, average ticket \$14.50, lunch rush 11-2 is 60% of sales, 6 line cooks, 12 front, inventory counted Sunday night by owner counting boxes, no depletion tracking, 86s mid-shift when cook yells. Trigger: \$8k food cost variance last month, staff giving free food to friends, double-entry online orders, labor 38% and can't tell if scheduling or theft, Square reports don't show per-location profit after food cost. Prior attempts: MarketMan for inventory 6 months ago — staff wouldn't log waste, too many steps; Toast demo last year — \$600/mo per location plus hardware and 3-year contract, too expensive; manager likes Clover but owner worries it's Square with different logo; stuck with Square because \$0 monthly but paying in other ways. Must-haves: unify DoorDash/Uber into one KDS no more three tablets, real inventory depletion linked to recipes (10 carnitas tacos deducts pork/tortillas), labor scheduling with clock-in and sales integration showing live labor %, staff permissions no void without manager PIN, offline mode South Lamar internet dropped 4 hours last month lost sales, per-location P&L; after food cost in one dashboard. Constraints: budget under \$500/mo total both locations including software and payments — Square payments 2.6% now, 2.9% kills on \$1.2M, hardware under \$2k total must work with existing iPads or low-cost, migrate in July slow month not SXSW or ACL, staff mostly Spanish-speaking need Spanish UI for KDS and hands-on training not YouTube videos. Risks: staff turnover train and quit in 2 weeks, KDS down during lunch rush 60% sales in 3 hours dead, inventory tracking adds steps cooks ignore like MarketMan, paying more for same problems — Toast/Clover just expensive Square with same food variance still not knowing theft vs waste. Success in 6 months: one dashboard both shops real profit after food and labor not just sales, food variance \$8k to under \$1.5k depletion/waste tracked, comps need manager PIN theft down, DoorDash/Uber in one KDS no tablets, labor 38% to 31% scheduling tied to sales, owner works 50 hours not 75 because no Sunday night box counting.

The decision

Switch from Square POS on iPads + DoorDash tablet + Uber Eats tablet + paper kitchen to unified restaurant POS with delivery integration into one KDS, recipe-level inventory depletion, live labor % with scheduling/clock-in, manager PIN for voids/comps, offline mode, and per-location P&L; after food cost, within \$500/mo total both locations and \$2k hardware cap, migrating July, or stay on Square and accept \$8k food variance, 38% labor, and tablet chaos if no system meets payment rate, adoption, and reliability criteria.

Decision maker

Restaurant Owner — owns 2 fast-casual taco shops Austin (South Lamar 3 years, Burnet 11 months), 35 employees, \$1.2M combined, handles ops, wife marketing, manages per-location profitability.

Situation

Two locations: South Lamar 3 years, Burnet 11 months, fast-casual tacos, 35 employees (6 line cooks, 12 front), \$1.2M combined annual, \$14.50 average ticket, 1,800 tickets/week across both, 40% takeout, 25% delivery through DoorDash/Uber, 35% dine-in, lunch rush 11-2 is 60% of sales. Current stack: Square POS on iPads since day one, DoorDash tablet, Uber Eats tablet, handwritten kitchen tickets, manual inventory Sunday night counting boxes, no depletion tracking, 86s mid-shift when cook yells. Financial: \$8k food cost variance last month, staff comp theft giving free food to friends, double-entered online orders, labor 38% can't tell scheduling vs theft, Square reports don't show per-location profit after food cost. Infrastructure: South Lamar internet dropped 4 hours

last month lost sales. Staff: mostly Spanish-speaking, high turnover — train and quit in 2 weeks. Seasonal: can't switch during SXSW or ACL, need July slow month.

Desired outcome

In 6 months: one dashboard both shops real profit after food and labor not just sales, food cost variance from \$8k to under \$1.5k because depletion and waste tracked and comps require manager PIN, DoorDash/Uber unified into one KDS no more three tablets, labor from 38% to 31% because scheduling tied to sales with clock-in, owner works 50 hours not 75 because no Sunday night box counting, KDS reliable during lunch rush 60% of sales, staff adoption despite turnover with Spanish UI.

Prior experience

- Square POS since day one — \$0 monthly but no inventory depletion, no per-location P&L; after food cost, no manager PIN controls, no offline resilience
- MarketMan for inventory 6 months ago — staff wouldn't log waste, too many steps, cooks ignored it
- Toast demo last year — \$600/mo per location plus hardware and 3-year contract, felt expensive vs Square, owner hesitated
- Clover liked by manager — owner worries it's just Square with different logo, same problems

Priorities

- Unify DoorDash/Uber Eats into one KDS — eliminate three tablets and handwritten tickets, no double entry
- Real inventory depletion linked to recipes — 10 carnitas tacos deducts pork and tortillas, waste logging simple enough for cooks to use
- Labor scheduling with clock-in and sales integration — live labor % dashboard, not after-the-fact
- Staff permissions — no void/comps without manager PIN to control theft
- Offline mode — South Lamar internet dropped 4 hours, must keep selling offline and sync later
- Per-location P&L; after food cost in one dashboard for both South Lamar and Burnet

Constraints

- Budget under \$500/mo total both locations including software and payments — Square payments 2.6% now, 2.9% kills on \$1.2M
- Hardware under \$2k total — must work with existing iPads or low-cost KDS screens, not \$5k Toast hardware
- Migrate in July slow month — cannot switch during SXSW or ACL festivals, lunch rush risk
- Staff mostly Spanish-speaking — need Spanish UI for KDS and hands-on training, not YouTube videos
- 35 employees with high turnover — training must be fast, POS intuitive for 2-week tenure staff

Options considered

- Stay on Square + DoorDash tablet + Uber tablet + paper kitchen — \$0 monthly but \$8k food variance, 38% labor, double entry, no per-location P&L; tablet chaos continues
- Toast POS with Toast KDS and Toast inventory — unified delivery, recipe depletion, labor, but \$600/mo per location + hardware + 3-year contract, payment rate 2.99%, may exceed \$500/mo total and \$2k hardware cap
- Clover + marketplace integration — manager likes it, but risk of being expensive Square with same food variance and theft issues

- Square for Restaurants upgrade + MarketMan retry with simpler waste logging — keeps Square ecosystem and iPads but requires staff adoption that failed before
- Cloud POS like SpotOn or Lightspeed Restaurant — mid-market, may meet \$500/mo and Spanish KDS but need to validate offline mode and delivery tablet unification

Tradeoffs

- Staying on Square avoids \$500/mo and hardware cost but continues \$8k food variance, theft via comps without PIN, 38% labor unknown, Sunday night box counting 75-hour weeks
- Toast gives unified KDS and recipe depletion and labor live % but costs near \$600/location + hardware, 3-year lock, and 2.99% payments on \$1.2M adds \$3,600/year vs 2.6%, plus hardware over \$2k cap
- Upgrading Square keeps iPads and low cost but MarketMan retry risks same staff adoption failure — cooks ignored waste logging before
- Cheap hardware saves \$2k cap but risks KDS downtime during lunch rush 11-2 which is 60% sales — if KDS down during rush, dead
- Adding manager PIN for voids/comps controls theft but slows front staff during rush if manager not nearby — need quick PIN or Face ID

Risks and concerns

- Staff turnover — train on POS and they quit in 2 weeks, Spanish-speaking need Spanish UI and simple training or adoption fails
- KDS reliability during lunch rush — 60% sales 11-2, if KDS goes down or internet drops (South Lamar 4-hour outage) lose sales
- Inventory adoption risk — if depletion tracking adds steps cooks ignore like MarketMan, food variance stays \$8k
- Paying more for same problems — Toast or Clover may be expensive Square with same variance, still not knowing theft vs waste
- Payment rate increase — 2.6% to 2.9% on \$1.2M is \$3,600 extra per year, wipes margin if food variance not fixed
- Migration timing — switching during SXSW or ACL or lunch rush chaos could cause ticket loss

Unknowns

- Which POS actually unifies DoorDash/Uber into one KDS without tablets and provides Spanish KDS UI?
- Real food variance reduction — can recipe depletion and waste logging get \$8k to under \$1.5k with 35 staff and high turnover?
- Payment rate negotiation — can Toast/SpotOn/Clover match 2.6% or near it on \$1.2M volume within \$500/mo total?
- Offline mode performance — does KDS and POS keep selling during internet drop and sync later without double entry?
- Hardware reuse — can existing iPads be reused for KDS or new low-cost screens under \$2k total both locations?

Decision criteria

- Unified delivery — DoorDash/Uber into one KDS, no more three tablets, no handwritten tickets, Spanish UI for KDS

- Recipe-level inventory depletion linked to sales — pork/tortillas deducted when carnitas tacos sold, simple waste logging cooks will use
- Live labor % — scheduling with clock-in and sales integration, per-location P&L; after food cost in one dashboard both locations
- Manager PIN for voids/comps to control theft, offline mode proven during South Lamar 4-hour internet drop
- Total cost under \$500/mo both locations including software + payments near 2.6%, hardware under \$2k total, existing iPads reused if possible, migrate July not SXSW/ACL with hands-on Spanish training

Next steps

1. Audit one week of tickets — 1,800 tickets across both, 40% takeout 25% delivery 35% dine-in, count 86s and comps without PIN to quantify \$8k variance theft vs waste
2. Shortlist 3 POS: Toast, Clover, and one mid-market (SpotOn/Lightspeed) that claim delivery unification into KDS, recipe depletion, Spanish KDS, offline mode, and payment rate near 2.6% within \$500/mo total and \$2k hardware
3. Demo script: lunch rush 11-2 with 60% sales, DoorDash/Uber order flows into one KDS, sell 10 carnitas tacos, show pork/tortilla depletion, void requires manager PIN, clock-in shows live labor %, internet off 10 min offline sale syncs, per-location P&L; after food cost dashboard
4. Validate references from 2-location fast-casual owners with Spanish-speaking staff and high turnover on adoption and KDS reliability during rush and internet outage
5. Select POS, negotiate payment rate near 2.6% and \$500/mo total cap, order hardware under \$2k, plan July migration with hands-on Spanish training and offline test at South Lamar

Recommendation

Do not stay on Square + tablets if food variance stays \$8k and labor 38% unknown — tablet chaos costs more than \$0 monthly. Proceed only with POS that proves in demo: DoorDash/Uber into one KDS with Spanish UI, recipe depletion that cooks will actually use (not MarketMan steps), manager PIN for voids/comps, live labor % with scheduling and clock-in, offline mode during internet drop, per-location P&L; after food cost, total cost under \$500/mo both locations including payments near 2.6% and hardware under \$2k, July migration with hands-on Spanish training, and reference from similar 2-location fast-casual with high turnover. If no POS meets payment rate and adoption criteria, stay on Square, add simple waste log sheet and manager PIN workaround via Square permissions, and hire part-time inventory counter to cut Sunday 75-hour weeks while re-evaluating after ACL.

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